You Can't Trust the Male

By Randy Noojin

SCENE: *A night class room.*
HARVEY KESSEL *is a man in his mid-thirties and he's sopping wet.*
LAURA SPIVEY *enters. She's an attractive woman around* Harvey's *age. She has an umbrella, a big bag, a purse and a Beginning Spanish book. She's wet and late.*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR:	*Some crimes are more serious than others. Most people will agree that stealing candy from a grocery store is less serious than robbing a bank. Most people will agree that robbing a bank is less serious than killing someone. But what about stealing someone's mail . . . that's no so bad, right?*
ACTRESS:	*Meet Harvey, a painfully shy young mailman, who falls in love-at-first-sight with . .*
ACTOR:	*Laura, a feisty young Brooklyn woman. He's dying to ask her out, but he doesn't know how to begin and then there never seems to be a perfect time and then he doesn't know what to say and then he doesn't want to bother her and then he just plain chickens out.*
ACTRESS:	*Finally, when a card comes through the mail to Laura canceling the first meeting of a night class she's signed up for, SOMEONE decides not to deliver it and goes to meet her there, knowing that he and she will be the only ones to attend.*
ACTOR:	*It all goes to show . . .*
TOGETHER:	*You Can't Trust the Male by Randy Noojin*

HARVEY: Hello.

LAURA: Intro to Spanish, right?

HARVEY: Si.

LAURA: Where is everybody? I thought I was late.

HARVEY: I don't know. I just got here.

LAURA: Are we in the right room?

HARVEY: 36A

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LAURA: Well, it's five after. We got the right date? *[She checks her registration card.]*

HARVEY: Friday the sixth. I wonder where is everybody. *[He goes to the door and looks down the hall.]*

LAURA: Yeah, this is ridiculous. There was a lady in the office. I'll go check.

HARVEY: We should give 'em a while longer. We're in the right place at the right time.

LAURA: I'll go make sure.

HARVEY: Oh, you know what? Hold on. Lemme check something.

LAURA: I just checked the schedule.

HARVEY: No, I know. This is not the schedule. I know, I did get that too, but this is something else. I didn't really-oh, yeah, here we go. *[He finds a postcard in his jacket pocket.]* Oh, no. Intro to Spanish is rescheduled for Tuesdays at eight!?

LAURA: What?

HARVEY: I shoulda read this.

LAURA: Lemme see that. I NEVER GOT THIS! Goddamn it! What next?! How come everything is picking *now* to happen? *[She takes his card to her desk and copies the information.]* These are the most incompetent, disorganized, stupid bunch I ever had to deal with in my life.

HARVEY: They probably sent you one, it's gonna come tomorrow.

LAURA: Yeah! Tomorrow! Why don't they *call* us? Would that be brilliant? A mailbox is a wishin' well in Brooklyn.

HARVEY: Well, something's bound to fall through the cracks occasionally.

LAURA: Thanks. They don't need an occasion to *mess* up in Brooklyn. They need a business day.

HARVEY: Well, this time a year, you know. Christmas cards and parcels pouring in. It's a flood.

LAURA: That's exactly why they should call. Everybody knows you can't trust the mail.

HARVEY: Well, it'll get there eventually, I bet, but you're right.

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LAURA: What, is your dad a mailman or something?

HARVEY: No, no.

LAURA: Hold it-

HARVEY: He's a mechanic.

LAURA: Oh, my God, I'm sorry.

HARVEY: What?

LAURA: I thought I'd seen you before.

HARVEY: I doubt it.

LAURA: Oh, God. Aren't you my mailman?

HARVEY: Your mailman?!

LAURA: You look just like my mailman.

HARVEY: You're kidding?

LAURA: 294 Vanderbilt Avenue. Fort Greene.

HARVEY: Well, yeah, that's my route. I thought you looked-yeah, I guess maybe that might be it.

LAURA: I'm sorry.

HARVEY: No, no.

LAURA: I wasn't sayin' it was your fault.

HARVEY: No, I know.

LAURA: I didn't mean it was the mailmen. It's the post office probably.

HARVEY: You don't have to apologize. I know you didn't mean anything by it. It's funny. Ha. Forget it. But, yeah, hey, I'm your mailman! Wow! How are ya? Nice to meet ya. I'm Harvey,Harvey Kessel.

LAURA: Laura Spivey.

HARVEY: So we're both taking a Spanish class, huh?

LAURA: Yeah, weird, huh?

HARVEY: Why are you taking Spanish?

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LAURA: I'm goin' to Mexico the end of February.

HARVEY: Really? That's great.

LAURA: Yeah, I love the sound of the language.

HARVEY: *[In Spanish.]* My dog has no nose. How does he smell? Terrible. (Mi perro no tiene ninguna nariz. ¿Cómo él huele? Terrible)

LAURA: Hey, that's pretty good. What did you say? *[He resists.]* It was dirty?

HARVEY: No. Just . . . My dog has no nose. How does he smell? Terrible.

LAURA: Oh, ya know what? While I got ya here. Well, ifya think about it, could you shove the mail under the grating, that iron door-?

HARVEY: Sure.

LAURA: But only if it hasn't been rainin'. 'Cause the drain clogs.

HARVEY: Be glad to. No problem.

LAURA: Just if ya think about it. That would be great. The kids upstairs, I think, or somebody's been opening my mail. [She gets ready to go]

HARVEY: Oh, no. What makes you think that?

LAURA: Little rips. You know. It's no big deal, it's mostly just a feelin', but if it's no trouble.

HARVEY: Not at all. . . , what're you-? I don't know-you gotta-? I mean, it's early and it's Friday and everything and there's no class now and everything-I don't know. You gotta be somewhere?

LAURA: Yeah, I gotta meet my boyfriend uptown in a minute. You know.

HARVEY: Oh, okay. I was just wondering. Good night then.

LAURA: Or else I would.

HARVEY: No, that's cool.

LAURA: Maybe some other time.

HARVEY: Okay. You go ahead. See ya Tuesday. [LAURA *exits. A short beat. She re-enters.]*

LAURA: That was a pretty bad lie, wasn't it?

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HARVEY: No, no. It was an okay one. *[He's getting ready to go.]*

LAURA: I mean, it wasn't even logical. I'm here for a two-hour class and now I all of a sudden gotta meet my boyfriend uptown in a minute? Bad lie.

HARVEY: We say whatever.

LAURA: I just wanna set the record straight. I do not have to be anywhere and I definitely do not have a boyfriend. I'm just-I'm a mess. So, believe me you don't wanna have anything to do with me right now.

HARVEY: What's wrong?

LAURA: Ahhh. I recently discovered I almost moved in with a lying *jerk* from hell.

HARVEY: I'm sorry.

LAURA: Yeah, so I'm in a bad mood. But, thanks though. Some other time.

HARVEY: Fine. That's fine. You let me know.

LAURA: Sorry I lied. . I'm not usually like this. I haven't slept. My brain against my will keeps playin' this dirty movie starring this guy and a beach fulla girls who're prettier than me.

HARVEY: Nobody's prettier than you.

LAURA: Oh, please. I'm a wreck.

HARVEY: You'll be fine. It passes eventually, but the only way out is through.

LAURA: I guess.

HARVEY: Oh, and one other thing. Never keep a Dear John letter. My advice is to burn it immediately if you haven't already. How long were you together?

LAURA: Two years.

LAURA: How did you know it was a letter? I never said I got a Dear John letter. How did you know it was a letter?

HARVEY: What was? No, I was just saying about *my* Dear John--that I burned it.

LAURA: Plus you got this thing that says there's no class tonight, that I didn't get, and you're my mailman. Have you been reading my mail?

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HARVEY: What're you talkin' about? I never read your mail. That's a felony! That's crazy. I was just talkin' to ya.

LAURA: Really?

HARVEY: God, you are so paranoid.

LAURA: I KNOW IT! That's exactly why you gotta tell me the truth now. Am I crazy? It's possible. Have I finally gone crazy? I won't be mad. Just tell me.

HARVEY: You're not crazy. Forgive me. I read Alan's last letter.

LAURA: I KNEW IT!

HARVEY: Can I at least explain?

LAURA: Stay away from me.

HARVEY: Oh, Jesus, don't be scared of me. Please don't think I'm dangerous 'cause I'm not. I'm a chicken. If I wasn't a chicken I could just *ask a girl out* like everybody else seems to be able to do.

LAURA: What?

HARVEY: I'm sorry. Oh, God, what an idiot. I just--I think you are so beautiful. You weaken my knees sometimes you're so beautiful. I swear to God I could faint from you sometimes if I stopped trying not to. And I been trying to think of a way to say something to you since I got your route. But no way seemed like the perfect way and then there was never really a good time and then I didn't want to bother you and then I didn't know what to say and then I got a fever blister and then--I just plain chickened out. I admit it. I'm scared of you. I am. I mean, you think *you're* scared--oh, boy, oh, boy, oh, boy. Okay. To make a stupid story short, I read your registration stuff for class. I mean, that's not really personal, really.

LAURA: Yeah, it is!

HARVEY: You're right, but it gave me the idea that--maybe we could meet in the class and I could maybe, I don't know--impress you maybe a little.

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LAURA: Impress me?

HARVEY: I took two years of Spanish in high school. So I signed up and that was the plan. But then you started getting the airmails from Alan. And I thought for a while he might just be a friend or something but then he drew the little hearts in the corner that one time--

LAURA: I don't believe this.

HARVEY: So I was gonna cancel the class. I sold my book back. I was gonna do my best to just forget the whole thing, but--I was just-curious, I don't know--what kinda love letters a guy who could be with you would have to write--or something like that, I don't know. But what I read was not exactly a love letter.

LAURA: You read my Dear John letter!

HARVEY: Right, so last week when your postponement thing came, I didn't deliver it and I was gonna finally make myself, no matter what, ask you out tonight. I just-I screwed up. I know it was wrong. Everything I do is wrong, but I can't just not do anything anymore. So I just did *something,* anything, something, I didn't think and I'm sorry but I gotta be glad 'cause it's better at least than what I been doing which is not a thing. But the last thing in the world I wanted was to add to your troubles and I hope you do whatever it takes to make yourself feel better about this. And turn me down if that's what it'll take.

LAURA: You wanted a date?

HARVEY: Don't worry about me.

LAURA: I'm not worried about you.

HARVEY: I invaded your privacy and there's no excuse for that.

LAURA: There's excuses.

HARVEY: You have every right to be furious and it's not good to keep that in.

LAURA: Will ya shut up about it? I can't turn you in.

HARVEY: I don't understand. *[Pause.]*

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LAURA: Well, see-uh-okay, Alan's a SEAL. In the Navy. So sometimes he goes out on these special maneuvers where there's no--whatever, telecommunications or somethin'. Least that's what he told me, and me, like a moron's been lappin' it up the last two years. Who *knows* what's really the truth, but when he does this we correspond. So he goes out this time and I wrote him and I'm expecting a letter and I'm gettin' nothin', so I figure my mail must be bein' sent to his place.

HARVEY: Why?

LAURA: I was gonna move in with him next month, so I filled out one a those change of address things, but I figured they might coulda started it too soon. You know how they are over there.

HARVEY: You'd be surprised the job we do, but I know what you mean, go on.

LAURA: So I went to his place to see if my mail's in his box-and it's not-but guess what was? *[She produces an opened letter.]* A love letter from some woman named Brenda. I could not believe it.

HARVEY: Is that Alan's mail?

LAURA: Oh, shut up. You did it too.

HARVEY: Oh, boy, oh, boy.

LAURA: But what burns me is once I read this, I was gonna break it off wi th *him.* I was so proud a myself. I didn't wanna talk about it. I didn't wanna fight it out. I wrote this- *[She shows him a notebook.]* -like, what is it, two-and-a-half pages of "Get lost". I was waitin' to buy a stamp. But I got his Dear John before I could mail him mine.

HARVEY: Is there anything I can do?

LAURA: Nah, nobody can do anything.

HARVEY: I gotta tell ya, it's about all I can do to keep from kissing you right now. *[Beat.]*

LAURA: What size shoes do you wear?

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HARVEY: I know. I got giant feet.

LAURA: Are you a twelve? *[She gets shoes from her bag.]*

HARVEY: Eleven-and-a-half, twelve. Depends.

LAURA: Try these on.

HARVEY: What're these?

LAURA: They're good shoes.

HARVEY: You don't want 'em?

LAURA: If they fit you, you can have 'em.

HARVEY: These are great.

LAURA: See if they fit. *[He tries them on.]*

HARVEY: I really love these. They're great. I don't know what to say. This is so nice of you. They fit perfect. Thank you.

LAURA: You're welcome.

HARVEY: How come you *don't-oh,* these are Alan's shoes!

LAURA: They were gonna be, but not anymore.

HARVEY: I can't take these.

LAURA: No, please, if you like 'em keep 'em. I was gonna throw them off the D train into the river but we went local.

HARVEY: I can't. What if-you know-what if you guys make up?

LAURA: I wouldn't worry about that. They look good on you.

HARVEY: Well, before you start givin' his stuff away-you should probably read this. *[He pulls an airmail letter from his notebook.]* This came today. *[He holds the airmail letter out to her. She just looks at him.]*

LAURA: Ya know, if I were you I'd wonder if maybe I shouldn't be a mailman. This came today?

HARVEY: Came and went. *[She looks at it a second then holds it out to him.]*

LAURA: Take it back. I don't even wanna hear it. I'm never speakin' to him again. I don't

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care if he begs on his hands and knees.

HARVEY: He does quite a bit of beggin' in there. *[She examines the letter for rips.]*

LAURA: What, steam?

HARVEY: The laundromat on your corner. There's an exhaust vent.

LAURA: You are so lucky I had a recent fit of snoopiness.

HARVEY: I realize that. And I'm grateful. But that's the end of it. *[She opens letter. Reads..]*

LAURA: Oh, sweet God. This is a miracle. *[Pause. She's in sweet relief]* This is-He wants me back. Oh, God- Oh, my God, I can't believe it! It's a miracle. Harvey! A miracle just happened. Listen, could you do me a big favor?

HARVEY: I know, you want the shoes back.

LAURA: No. I want to send this letter back first class. *[She writes on envelope.]* Return to sender. Address unknown.

HARVEY: Oh, boy, oh, boy, oh, boy. *[Pause.]*

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